

creating a next-generation operating system to leap ahead of Windows had failed, the second coming of Steve Jobs and the acquisition of NeXT gave Apple one final window of opportunity.

It was a fundamental divergence from the classic Mac OS. This operating system was completely based on the XNU kernel and was very “Unix-like.” (XNU is the name of the kernel used in the open source Darwin computer operating system, which Apple uses as the foundation of Mac OS X. It is a hybrid kernel based on a mixed Mach kernel and the FreeBSD kernel codebase. XNU is a recursive acronym for “XNU is Not Unix.”) This ensured that it was extremely stable and secure. The core is called Darwin, and is completely open source. Apple added a lot of custom technologies to Darwin such as the QuickTime engine, the Aqua interface, Finder, etc. Pre-emptive multi-tasking and memory protection were some of the core technologies Apple introduced, which ensured that the OS could multi-task effectively with all the resources shared among the various applications as and when required. They also ensured that an application crash would not take down the entire system.

The Aqua interface was the most distinct addition to the Darwin core. It gave the operating system a beautiful, liquid sort of look and feel. Windows XP was released a short while after Mac OS X, and Mac users had the opportunity to sneer at the decidedly ugly looks of XP when compared to Cheetah. The Aqua interface has undergone a lot of refinement over the years and compared to the smooth and minimalist look of Tiger today, Cheetah looks a bit too gaudy; but at the time, it was the gold standard in interface design.

There have been five versions of OS X so far—Cheetah (March 2001), Puma (September 2001), Jaguar (August 2002), Panther (October 2003) and Tiger (April 2005). Though all the other versions had to be paid for, Puma was basically a bug-fix release that was released as a free update for existing Cheetah users. The forthcoming version of Mac OS X is called Leopard, and is expected to